Nishads in eastern UP, see Sanjay Pandey, 'Why Nishads are so important in eastern UP', *Deccan Herald*, 4 April 2019, https://www.deccanherald.com/national/why-nishads-are-so-important-in-eastern-up-727018.html.

25. Interview with Brijesh Shukla, columnist, *Navbharat Times*, 11 June 2020, Lucknow.
26. BJP also lost Kairana and Phulpur in that round of by-elections in 2018.
27. See, for example, IANS, 'Nishads emerge as major votebank in UP elections', *Business Standard*, 18 May 2019, https://www.business-standard.com/article/news-ians/nishads-emerge-as-major-vote-bank-in-up-elections-119051800408_1.html.
28. This switch by Praveen Nishad showed that Nishad groups were not passive recipients of a BJP indoctrination drive. Far from it. Nishad leaders responded to the BJP's overtures by playing the game instrumentally. For a detailed background on Nishad identity and politics, see Assa Doron, 'Caste away? Subaltern engagement with the modern Indian state', *Modern Asian Studies*, Vol. 44, No. 4, 2010, pp. 753–783.
29. Aman Sharma, 'High Court stays UP's move to shift 17 OBCs to SC list', *The Economic Times*, 17 September 2019, https://economictimes.indiatimes.com/news/politics-and-nation/high-court-stays-ups-move-to-shift-17-obcs-to-sc-list/articleshow/71160095.cms?from=mdr.
30. IANS, 'Uttar Pradesh adds 17 OBC groups to SC list', *The Hindu*, 30 June 2017, https://www.thehindu.com/news/national/other-states/up-adds-17-obc-groups-to-sc-list/article28231615.ece.
31. Pankaj Shah, 'UP panel suggests 7% quota for Yadavs & Kurmis, says they are politically influential', *The Times of India*, 18 December 2018, https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/city/lucknow/up-panel-suggests-7-quota-for-yadavs-kurmis-says-they-are-politically-influential/articleshow/67137290.cms.
32. Interview with Dinesh Sharma, deputy chief minister, UP, 8 June 2020, Lucknow.